“OUR NATIONAL LIFE IS FULL OF VARIETY. THERE ARE MANY LANGUAGES, MANY SECTS, MANY MODES OF LIFE AND MANY STYLES OF ART AND LITERATURE. THIS VARIETY IS THE SYMBOL OF THE RICHNESS OF OUR LIFE.”

Atal Bihari Vajpayee was India’s first non-Congress prime minister to complete a full five-year term. A member of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and Jana Sangh, Vajpayee was an excellent speaker and writer. He was first elected to Parliament in 1957. He would go on to be elected to the Lok Sabha several more times and spent a total of forty-seven years as an MP. In 1980, he helped form the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and was its first president. He took office as India’s prime minister in 1999, heading a coalition of twenty-four parties. During his tenure, Vajpayee made significant efforts to improve India-Pakistan relations and to end the violence in Kashmir. He also oversaw the further opening up of India’s economy, which led to a period of steady growth.